

Visual Reference Sheet

Descriptive Writing & Storytelling — Assignment #3

Created through collaboration with Claude — Anthropic

Use this sheet as a reference while planning and prompting. These lists are starting points — you are encouraged to research and explore beyond them.

1. Shot Types

The shot type tells the reader how close or far they are from the subject, and shapes how a panel feels emotionally.

- Extreme close-up — eyes, hands, a single object; intense, intimate
- Close-up — face and expression; emotional, revealing
- Medium shot — character from waist up; conversational, balanced
- Medium wide shot — character full body in partial environment
- Wide shot — character fully visible in their environment
- Extreme wide shot — character small in frame; scale, isolation, establishing
- Over-the-shoulder — from behind one character looking at another
- Bird's eye / top-down — looking straight down; vulnerability, surveillance
- Worm's eye / low angle — looking up at subject; power, dominance, threat
- Dutch angle — tilted frame; signals unease, tension, disorientation
- Point of view — seen through the character's eyes; immersive, subjective

→ Research manga and comic panel terminology to discover more shot types and how artists use them to control pacing.

2. Mood & Lighting

Mood and lighting work together to carry the emotional register of a panel. Specific lighting language produces far better AI results than vague words like 'dark' or 'bright'.

- Golden hour — warm, soft, nostalgic, safe
- Harsh midday light — flat, exposed, no shadows to hide in
- Blue hour / dusk — melancholic, transitional, uncertain
- Candlelight or firelight — intimate, flickering, dangerous warmth
- Moonlight — cold, lonely, mysterious, silver-toned
- Overcast — muted, heavy, unresolved, grey
- Chiaroscuro — sharp contrast between light and dark; dramatic, theatrical
- Silhouette — figure in shadow against a lit background; unknown, powerful
- Fog or mist — dreamlike, threatening, unclear
- Neon or artificial light — urban, unnatural, disorienting
- Backlit — subject outlined in light; vulnerable or transcendent
- Underlit — light from below; eerie, unsettling, theatrical

→ Mood and lighting can be combined — 'moonlit fog with neon reflections on wet pavement' is a complete lighting description that will produce a specific result.

3. Visual & Art Style

Choose one style and stay close to it across all panels. Consistency in style is what makes a comic feel like a unified work rather than a collection of unrelated images.

- Black and white ink with hatching — classic manga, high contrast, editorial

- Greyscale with ink wash — soft, atmospheric, painterly manga
- Limited colour palette (2–3 colours only) — graphic, deliberate, striking
- Full colour, painterly — rich, detailed, cinematic
- Flat colour with bold outlines — graphic novel style, clean, modern
- Watercolour — soft edges, dreamlike, emotional
- Rough sketch / unfinished linework — raw, energetic, expressive
- Cel-shaded — clean, animation-inspired, sharp shadows
- Woodblock print inspired — textured, traditional, high contrast
- Noir style — heavy shadows, high contrast, black and white or deep sepia
- Soft pastel — gentle, fragile, dreamlike
- Gritty urban realism — textured, worn, desaturated

→ Look up your favourite manga or comic artist and include their name or style in your prompt — e.g. 'in the style of Naoki Urasawa linework' or 'inspired by Moebius illustration'.

4. Atmosphere & Weather

Weather and atmosphere are not just background details — they are emotional information that the reader absorbs unconsciously.

- Heavy rain — grief, tension, movement, cleansing
- Snow falling — silence, isolation, softness, time suspended
- Thick fog — uncertainty, threat, the unknown just ahead
- Wind — shown through hair, cloth, debris; restlessness, change, force
- Oppressive heat — shown through shimmer, dust, stillness; suffocation, pressure
- Storm building — dark clouds, charged air; dread, anticipation
- Aftermath of rain — wet surfaces, reflections, quiet after tension
- Clear sky, vast and open — freedom, exposure, possibility

→ Combine atmosphere with lighting for richer prompts — 'heavy rain lit by neon signs, reflections on cobblestones' gives the AI specific visual instructions.

5. Colour Palette Suggestions

Telling the AI a specific palette keeps your pages visually consistent and prevents the tool from making random colour choices.

- Monochromatic — shades and tints of a single colour; unified, focused
- Warm tones — reds, oranges, yellows; urgency, danger, warmth, passion
- Cool tones — blues, greens, purples; calm, melancholy, mystery, detachment
- Desaturated / muted — washed out, exhausted, subdued, realistic
- High contrast black and white — graphic, bold, no ambiguity
- Earth tones — browns, ochres, deep greens; grounded, natural, ancient
- Split complementary — two contrasting colours and one neutral; dynamic but controlled
- Two-colour accent — primarily greyscale with one colour used sparingly for emphasis

→ Naming specific colours works well in prompts — 'deep teal and burnt orange palette with charcoal shadows' is more precise than 'warm colours'.

6. Composition Techniques

Composition is how the elements inside the panel are arranged. It controls where the reader's eye travels and what they notice first.

- Rule of thirds — subject placed off-centre; dynamic, natural, less static
- Symmetry — balanced, formal, can feel eerie or authoritative
- Leading lines — roads, corridors, or shadows that guide the eye toward the subject
- Negative space — deliberate emptiness around the subject; isolation, weight
- Frame within a frame — doorway, window, or arch surrounds the subject; trapped, observed
- Foreground element — something between viewer and subject; depth, voyeurism
- Crowded frame — multiple overlapping elements; claustrophobic, overwhelming, chaotic
- Empty frame — subject alone with vast space; isolation, stillness, aftermath

→ Composition can be described directly in your prompt — 'low angle wide shot, subject silhouetted in a doorway, negative space above'.

7. Character Expression Reference

Specific expression language produces far better AI results than general words like 'sad' or 'angry'. Describe what the face and body are physically doing.

- Jaw clenched, eyes downcast — suppressed emotion, shame, or quiet fury
- Wide eyes, pupils dilated — shock, fear, sudden realisation
- Half-lidded, unreadable — controlled, dangerous, watchful
- Tears not yet fallen — the moment before breaking; more powerful than crying
- Forced smile, tension around the eyes — performance of happiness, internal conflict
- Blank expression, dissociated — shock, numbness, disconnection
- Rage barely contained — still, tense body, clenched fists, steady gaze
- Exhausted beyond emotion — slack posture, vacant eyes, mouth slightly open
- Chin raised, steady gaze — defiance, resolve, dignity under pressure
- Shoulders hunched, arms crossed — withdrawal, self-protection, shame

→ Pair expression language with body language for stronger prompts — 'jaw clenched, shoulders pulled back, hands flat on a table' tells the AI a full physical story.

8. How to Build a Strong AI Image Prompt

A strong manga panel prompt layers multiple elements together. Use this structure as your checklist.

#	Element	What to include
1	Subject	Who or what is in the panel
2	Action or pose	What they are doing
3	Shot type	How close or far the camera is
4	Setting	Where this is happening
5	Mood or lighting	The emotional atmosphere
6	Art style	The visual register
7	Colour palette	What tones dominate

Example prompt structure:

"Medium close-up of a teenage girl with silver hair standing at the edge of a rain-soaked rooftop, fists clenched at her sides, jaw tight, looking down at the city below, dramatic backlit silhouette, blue hour lighting, deep blue and charcoal palette, black and white manga ink style with heavy shadows and fine hatching"

Tips for maintaining consistency across panels:

- Include the same character description in every prompt — hair, build, clothing, any defining feature
- Name the same art style in every prompt — do not switch between styles
- Keep the colour palette description identical across all panels
- If the tool allows, save your character seed or reference image and reuse it
- Write your base character description once and copy-paste it into every new prompt before customising